

A+E

Plan your summer fun around these concerts



Beyoncé, AC/DC, Oasis, the recently announced Lady Gaga, left, and lots more headline 100 of our picks for Chicagoland's best live music in the coming months



LIFE

‘WE’RE NOT SEEN’

Incarcerated Muslims try to find peace during Ramadan

WINNER OF 28 PULITZER PRIZES FOR EXCELLENCE IN JOURNALISM

Final

Chicago Tribune



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SUNDAY, MARCH 30, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



ROCKFORD RAMPAGE ONE YEAR LATER

‘I feel like I’m losing her all over again’

By Caroline Kubzansky
Chicago Tribune

ROCKFORD — Tabatha Banta thought the first few weeks after her daughter died would be the most difficult.

But she spent the last few weeks dreading the arrival of March 27.

“I feel like I’m losing her all over again,” she said. “But this time, I know it’s coming.”

Thursday was the year anniversary of Banta’s 15-year-old daughter Jenna Newcomb being fatally beaten with her own softball bat while at home during a sleepover with her younger sister and a friend.

The same day, authorities accused Christian Soto, now 23, of killing Jenna, Soto’s friend Jacob Schupbach, Jacob’s mother Romona Schupbach and the neighborhood’s beloved mail carrier, Jay Larson. Seven more people, including Jenna’s sister, were wounded. All of the attacks, in which Soto allegedly used a knife, the softball bat and his own truck to kill and attempt to kill people,

Neighbors, victims live with aftershocks of attacks that left four dead, seven wounded

Tabatha Banta reflects on her daughter, Jenna Newcomb, who was killed just over a year ago in a mass stabbing attack in Rockford. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

took place in the space of a few residential blocks of southeast Rockford.

A year later, cases against Soto are pending in court. Some of the people involved have moved away, neighbors said, including the Schupbach survivors and a family that allegedly fought back against Soto with a bottle of syrup when he broke into their home. And a police substation, discussed before the killings, is now in the works at the outskirts of the area. People lock their doors now.

Rockford Mayor Tom McNamara pointed out that while the deaths hit the neighborhood the hardest, all of Rockford — population just over 146,000 — felt the ripple effects.

“It impacted every single person who calls Rockford home,” he said.

Many residents have watched the early stages of the court cases unfold and have asked themselves why this happened. Soto, who grew up in the neighborhood and had

Shift for pretrial monitor program

Cook County’s overhaul of electronic observation jolts debate about public safety

By Madeline Buckley and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

After months of planning and discussion, the Cook County sheriff’s office starting Tuesday will no longer accept new electronic monitoring participants, marking the beginning of a shift in one way pretrial justice is handled in Cook County.

The county will now run all electronic monitoring through the court system, merging parallel programs that have previously operated separately under the authority of Sheriff Tom Dart and Chief Judge Tim Evans. Often used as something of a middle ground between being released or jailed pretrial, both programs use GPS technology to oversee defendants that judges determine need additional supervision, even though they aren’t ordered to remain in jail.

Officials have discussed merging the electronic monitoring programs for years, but the move became a reality last year when Dart announced he would no longer take new clients. The change was supported by Cook County Board President Toni Preckwinkle, but was initially resisted by Evans.

It’s a large undertaking: The chief judge’s office needs new staff, new space and the money to pay for both. Evans’ office estimated it would cost about \$10 million this year alone as its responsibilities ramp up. It is also poised to set off battles with unions that represent sheriff’s office personnel whose electronic monitoring roles will no longer be needed as that program ramps down.

Turn to Monitor, Page 6

NATION & WORLD

Trump’s voting order has officials concerned

President Donald Trump’s executive order that seeks to change how U.S. elections are run is creating uncertainty for state and local election officials and worries about voter confusion before the next federal election, the 2026 midterms.

When a ‘lifeline’ disappears

Man’s brother detained by ICE while trying to donate kidney

By Laura Rodríguez Presa
Chicago Tribune

For the past year, three days a week for four hours, Alfredo Pacheco, 37, has been undergoing dialysis. Most days, even if he feels ill, he pushes himself to work after the procedure, thinking of his three young children who wait to see him again one day back in Venezuela.

As time passes, however, he feels weaker and a bit more tired every day, he said.

Pacheco was diagnosed with end-stage renal disease not long after arriving in Chicago seeking asylum. It was then that doctors told him that he needed a kidney transplant, “or else I would die,” he said. Medical records also show the acute illness that has drastically changed his life.

His older brother, José Gregorio

González, 43, who was denied entry to the country at the southern border, tried to enter once again hoping to donate a kidney to save his brother’s life. He managed to cross and stay in the United States under immigration supervision.

After a long and complicated process to get approved for the transplant under public insurance, the brothers had an appointment in a Chicago hospital in April to go forward with more tests for the organ exchange. But on March 3, González was arrested by U.S. Immigration and Customs authorities and now awaits deportation at Clay County Detention Center in Indiana, leaving Pacheco, once again, desperate and fighting for his life.

The two are pleading with immigration authorities to release González on humanitarian parole to donate the kidney. “After that, I will return to Venezuela,” González said from a call in the detention center.

Turn to Kidney, Page 8



Alfredo Pacheco, a Venezuelan immigrant who earlier this year was diagnosed with end-stage kidney failure, displays a photo of himself and his brother José Gregorio González on Wednesday in Cicero. González, also an immigrant from Venezuela, was set to donate a kidney to his brother but was detained by ICE agents. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

TODAY’S WEATHER



High 70 Low 36

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 18

\$5.75 city and suburbs and elsewhere
177th year No. 89 © Chicago Tribune

